

Product Requirements Document

Merchant Payment Operations & Dispute Hub: MVP

Document	Product Requirements Document (PRD)
Version and status	1.2, draft for review
Date	11 September 2026
Product Owner	Bhawna
Approvers	Business Sponsor (MVP scope); Steering Committee (High-impact scope changes)
Reviewers	Dispute Ops Lead, Finance Lead, Tech Lead, Compliance Lead, InfoSec Lead, Merchant Relationship Lead
Target release	MVP go-live 11 December 2026, followed by a 10-merchant pilot from 11 January 2027
Related documents	RAID Log, Change Log, Product Backlog, Requirements Traceability Matrix, KPI Definitions, Business Case & GTM Plan, Engagement Plan, Post-Launch Plan, Product Roadmap, Discovery & Decision Log, Wireframes, SQL Practice Pack

Simulation project. This PRD was prepared as a portfolio exercise to demonstrate Product Owner practice. It does not describe an actual client system. Volumes, costs, dates, teams, vendors and reason codes are illustrative.

Contents

The project in plain words

1. Executive summary
2. Problem statement
3. Goals and non-goals
4. Users and personas
5. User journeys
6. Scope
7. Functional requirements
8. Non-functional and compliance requirements
9. Data, integrations and status model
10. Experience requirements
11. Analytics and instrumentation
12. Success metrics
13. Release plan and milestones
14. Dependencies, risks and assumptions
15. Open questions and decisions needed
16. Launch readiness, post-launch and beyond MVP
17. Appendices

The project in plain words

A short, non-technical explanation of the Dispute Hub for anyone new to payments or to this project.

What a dispute is

Sometimes a customer calls their bank and says “I didn't get what I paid for” or “I didn't make this purchase.” The bank takes the money back from the shop. This is called a dispute, or chargeback. The shop gets a deadline, usually 20 to 30 days, to prove the sale was genuine, for example with a receipt or proof of delivery. If the shop proves it, they get the money back. If they miss the deadline, they lose automatically, even if they were right.

The problem today

All of this happens over email.

- Shops don't notice the deadline and lose money they shouldn't have lost.
- They email receipts and screenshots to the dispute team, who copy everything into another system by hand. That's slow and tiring.
- Shops can't see what's happening with their dispute, so they keep calling for updates.
- Some screenshots contain full card numbers sitting in email, which is a security risk.
- Finance and operations can't agree on how many disputes are being won.

What the Dispute Hub does

It gives every shop one simple online place to:

- See all their disputes and how many days are left on each.
- Get reminder emails before deadlines.
- Upload their proof and send it in one step, with card numbers hidden automatically.
- Track what happened and see how disputes affected their payouts.

Behind the scenes, the dispute team gets a tidy to-do list instead of a messy inbox, and everyone uses the same numbers.

Why it matters

Shops win more of the disputes they deserve to win. The dispute team saves time. Card data stays safe. And the company can show clearly whether it's working.

The Product Owner's role

The Product Owner decides what gets built first, keeps everyone agreeing on the plan, handles changes and risks, and measures whether the product succeeds. The PRD and its companion workbooks show how that work is run.

In one sentence

A self-service portal where merchants track card disputes, get deadline reminders and submit evidence online, so they stop losing disputes to missed deadlines and the ops team stops processing everything by email.

This is a simulation project built to demonstrate Product Owner practice. It isn't a real client system, but it is modelled on how payment dispute teams work.

1. Executive summary

Merchants currently handle card disputes through email and spreadsheets. Deadlines are tracked by hand, evidence is emailed back and forth to dispute operations, and neither merchants nor servicing agents can see where a dispute stands. The result is disputes lost simply because nobody responded in time, high manual effort for dispute ops, avoidable settlement queries, and card data sitting in email attachments.

The Dispute Hub gives merchants one self-service place to see every open dispute and its deadline, upload and submit evidence safely, and understand how disputes affect their payouts. Behind the portal, it connects to the payment processor for real-time status updates, redacts card numbers from evidence, gives dispute ops a prioritized work queue, and gives ops and finance one trusted set of dispute numbers.

The MVP covers nine epics and 42 backlog items (252 story points), delivered in ten two-week sprints for go-live on 11 December 2026. Rollout is pilot-led: 10 enterprise merchants first, then two waves by segment, then general availability in Q4 2027, with KPI-based go / no-go gates between each phase.

What success looks like:

- On-time responses rise from 78% to 95%, and disputes lost to missed deadlines fall from 9% to 3%.
- Dispute ops handling time falls from 42 to 25 minutes per dispute, and 70% of evidence arrives through the portal.
- No full card numbers are stored or displayed anywhere in the hub.
- The base business case returns an NPV of about \$149k over three years with payback 2.3 years after go-live. The conservative case is negative, which makes adoption and ops capacity treatment the assumptions to validate early.

Decisions needed now: the CR-05 dispute outcome definitions (due 18 September), the CR-01 fraud case management scope (steering committee, 24 September), the CR-06 UAT approach while the penetration test date is late (25 September), and approval of the analytics tracking plan (I-06).

2. Problem statement

2.1 How disputes work today

When a cardholder disputes a transaction, the processor notifies the provider and dispute ops emails the merchant, who must respond with evidence before a deadline set by card network rules. Merchants reply by email with receipts, invoices and screenshots. Dispute ops re-keys the evidence into the processor, chases missing documents and tracks deadlines in spreadsheets. Merchants can't see status or deadlines themselves, servicing agents can't answer dispute calls, and finance and ops calculate dispute results differently.

2.2 Who is affected

Who	Pain today	Evidence (baseline, illustrative)
Merchants	Miss deadlines they didn't know about; lose money on disputes they could have won; can't explain payout changes	78% on-time response rate (KPI-03); 9% of closed disputes lost to missed deadlines (KPI-04); 38% value recovery rate (KPI-01)
Dispute operations	Manual email intake, re-keying evidence and chasing merchants; no prioritized queue	42 minutes of handling per dispute (August 2026 time study, KPI-05); 100% of evidence arrives by email (KPI-06)
Finance	Two conflicting win-rate definitions; settlement debits and reversals hard to reconcile	Finance and ops win rates differ by more than 20 points on the same disputes (I-05)

Who	Pain today	Evidence (baseline, illustrative)
Customer servicing	Can't see dispute status, so transfers callers to dispute ops	14 settlement queries per 100 merchants per month (KPI-07)
Compliance	Card numbers appear in emailed evidence, expanding PCI DSS exposure	Card data in unmanaged mailboxes (R-02)

2.3 Cost of not solving it

Merchants keep losing disputes to process failures rather than on merits, which drives dissatisfaction and attrition. Ops cost scales linearly with dispute volume, and seasonal peaks stretch the team. Card data in email remains a compliance exposure, and leadership continues to receive dispute numbers that finance and ops don't agree on.

3. Goals and non-goals

3.1 Goals

Goal	Measure	Baseline	End of 2027	End of 2028
G1. Merchants respond before deadlines	On-time response rate (KPI-03) Missed-deadline loss rate (KPI-04)	78% 9%	91% 5%	95% 3%
G2. Reduce manual dispute ops effort	Ops handling time per dispute (KPI-05)	42 min	29 min	25 min
G3. Make the portal the default dispute channel	Portal evidence share (KPI-06)	0%	55%	62% (70% in 2029)
G4. Help merchants recover more disputed value	Value recovery rate (KPI-01, pending CR-05)	38%	42%	45%
G5. Keep card data protected	Card data exposure incidents (KPI-16)	Not measured	0	0
G6. One trusted set of dispute numbers	Agreed outcome definitions; reconciliation variance (KPI-15)	Two definitions	One definition; ≤ 0.5%	≤ 0.5%

Interim targets follow the quarterly benefits path in the Post-Launch Plan, which rolls up to the base business case.

3.2 Non-goals

Not in the MVP	Why	Where it's tracked
Fraud case management inside the hub	Adds about two sprints and depends on a fraud service that is already late. A read-only fraud case reference may be included if CR-01 Option C is approved.	CR-01, D-07, roadmap IR-06
Spanish language portal	Pilot merchants accepted an English portal with a Spanish PDF guide.	CR-04 (deferred), IR-07
SMS deadline reminders	Needs an SMS vendor and consent review before sizing.	CR-09 (under assessment), IR-05
Marketplace sub-merchant disputes	Requires a sub-merchant data model not in MVP scope.	Segments tab, IR-10

Not in the MVP	Why	Where it's tracked
Admin screen for editing reason codes	Reason codes are configurable reference data in MVP; a self-service screen can follow.	CR-02 Option C, IR-04
Nightly email files of dispute data	Doesn't meet data security requirements; the need is met by CSV export.	CR-08 (rejected)
Automated dispute decisions (for example auto-accept rules)	Needs outcome data from the live product first.	IR-09
Prevention and AI capabilities: pre-dispute alerts, AI evidence copilot, friendly fraud automation, dispute ratio health, root-cause insights, AI agent purchase readiness	Beyond-MVP differentiators. Each needs discovery, compliance review and a business case before commitment.	RM-25 to RM-30, DSC-07 to DSC-15, section 16.4

4. Users and personas

Persona	Goal	Key pain today	What they do in the hub
Merchant operations user	Respond to every dispute on time with the right evidence	Deadlines hidden in email; unclear what evidence wins	Works the dispute inbox, uploads evidence, submits or accepts disputes
Merchant finance user	Reconcile payouts and understand dispute impact	Payout changes arrive without explanation	Reviews settlements, debits and reversals; exports to CSV
Merchant admin	Give the team the right access and see results	No control over who handles disputes	Invites users, assigns roles, completes onboarding
Dispute ops analyst	Clear disputes in priority order with less re-keying	Manual intake and chasing	Works the ops queue and manual review queue
Servicing agent	Answer dispute and payout questions on the first call	No visibility of dispute status	Looks up dispute status through the agent console
Compliance officer	Keep card data protected and evidence auditable	Card data in email; no audit trail	Reviews audit history, redaction results and control evidence

5. User journeys

5.1 Merchant responds to a dispute

Step	Today	With the Dispute Hub
Notice	Email from dispute ops, sometimes missed	Dispute appears in the inbox with its due date; email reminders at 5 and 2 days
Understand	Look up the reason code or call servicing	Plain-language reason with suggested evidence types
Gather evidence	Collect files and email them to ops	Upload PDF, JPG or PNG files; card numbers redacted automatically
Respond	Ops re-keys evidence into the processor	Submit in one step, or accept the dispute with a clear warning

Step	Today	With the Dispute Hub
Track	Chase ops by email or phone	Status and 'last synced' time visible; outcome notification when closed

5.2 Dispute ops handles work

Step	Today	With the Dispute Hub
Intake	Read mailbox, match emails to disputes	Portal submissions go straight to the processor; only exceptions reach ops
Prioritize	Spreadsheet sorted by hand	Work queue ordered by due date with the reason each item needs action
Exceptions	Unknown reason codes found late	Unmapped codes routed to a manual review queue; feed outage alert after 2 hours
Report	Manual extracts; figures disputed by finance	Power BI dashboard using agreed outcome definitions

5.3 Finance user reconciles a payout

Step	Today	With the Dispute Hub
Spot a change	Payout lower than expected	Settlement summary shows gross sales, fees, chargeback debits, reversals and net payout
Explain it	Call servicing and wait	Each debit and reversal links to its dispute
Reconcile	Manual matching in spreadsheets	CSV export of the filtered view; provisional label where data failed quality checks

6. Scope

The MVP is organized into nine epics. Story counts and points come from the Product Backlog (MVP items only; items awaiting a change decision are excluded).

Epic	Outcome	Success measure	MVP items	Points
EP-01 Merchant Access & Onboarding	Merchants sign in securely, get the right access for their role and start using the portal without training calls.	Pilot activation rate of at least 60% within 4 weeks	5	28
EP-02 Dispute Inbox & Tracking	Merchants see every open dispute, its status and deadline in one place.	Share of disputes opened in the portal before their deadline	6	32
EP-03 Evidence Submission	Merchants respond to disputes with evidence through the portal instead of email, without exposing card data.	Share of evidence submitted through the portal	6	45
EP-04 Processor Integration	Dispute data and statuses flow reliably between the processor and the hub.	Status update latency under 5 minutes; no missed deadlines caused by sync failures	7	47
EP-05 Notifications & Reminders	Merchants are reminded before deadlines and told about outcomes.	Rate of disputes lost due to missed deadlines	2	10
EP-06 Settlement Visibility	Merchants understand their payouts, including chargeback debits and reversals.	Reduction in settlement-related support contacts	3	19

Epic	Outcome	Success measure	MVP items	Points
EP-07 Reporting & Analytics	Ops, finance and product teams work from consistent, trusted numbers.	Reconciliation variance within 0.5%; weekly dashboard use by ops and finance	4	23
EP-08 Internal Ops Workbench	Dispute ops work disputes in priority order with full context.	Average handling time per dispute	1	8
EP-09 Platform Quality & Compliance	The platform is secure, accessible, performant and ready for go-live sign-off.	Security, accessibility and performance sign-offs complete before go-live	8	40
Total			42	252

Awaiting a decision: US-036 fraud case reference (CR-01) and US-027 SMS reminders (CR-09). Phase 2 candidates: fraud case management, Spanish portal and reason code admin screen.

7. Functional requirements

Priority: **P0** means the MVP can't launch without it; **P1** is important, with a workaround available. Requirement IDs match the Requirements Traceability Matrix, and full Given / When / Then acceptance criteria live on the linked backlog stories.

ID	Requirement	Priority	Acceptance summary	Stories
BR-01	Merchants can view all open disputes, their status and response deadlines in one self-service portal.	P0	Inbox shows ID, amount, reason, status and due date for every open dispute. Filters by status, reason and due date. Due within 5 days shows amber; within 2 days shows red at the top. Passed deadlines are marked.	US-006 US-008 US-009 US-011
BR-02	Merchant users sign in with company single sign-on and receive role-based access (Admin, Finance, Operations).	P0	SSO sign-in lands on the inbox. Admin, Finance and Operations roles control screens and actions. Disabled accounts are denied and logged. Sessions expire after 15 minutes idle.	US-001 US-002 US-003
BR-03	Merchants can upload evidence and submit a dispute response to the processor before the deadline.	P0	PDF, JPG and PNG up to 10 MB each. Invalid files show a clear error and nothing is stored. One-step submission changes status to Evidence submitted. Processor rejections show the reason and allow resubmission. Attachments become read-only after submission; upload is disabled after the deadline.	US-012 US-015 US-017
BR-05	Merchants can accept a dispute without contesting it.	P1	Accepting requires confirmation that states the amount won't be recovered. Status changes to Accepted and the acceptance is sent to the processor.	US-016
BR-06	New disputes are received from the processor automatically without duplicates, and status changes are reflected within 5 minutes.	P0	New disputes are created once with all mandatory fields; duplicates are prevented. Invalid records go to an error queue. Status updates apply within 5 minutes (p95). Unknown statuses keep the last status and raise an alert; polling is the fallback.	US-018 US-019 US-020

ID	Requirement	Priority	Acceptance summary	Stories
BR-07	Dispute reason codes and response windows can be updated without a code release, with a history of each change.	P0	Reason codes and response windows update through reference data without a release. Previous values, change date and approver are kept. Unmapped codes route to manual review.	US-021 US-022
BR-08	Ops are alerted when the processor feed stops updating, and merchants can see when data was last synced.	P0	'Last synced' time shown in the user's time zone, with a warning after 2 hours. Ops are alerted after 2 hours without updates during business hours, with a recovery message when the feed resumes.	US-010 US-023
BR-09	Merchants receive reminders before deadlines and notifications of dispute outcomes, and can opt out of emails.	P0	Reminder emails at 5 and 2 days before the due date when no evidence is submitted; none after submission. Opt-outs are honored and recorded. Finance and Admin users are notified of final outcomes.	US-025 US-026
BR-10	Merchants can view settlements, including chargeback debits and reversals, and export them to CSV.	P0	Settlement summary by payout date shows gross sales, fees, chargeback debits, reversals and net payout. Debits and reversals link to disputes. CSV export matches the filtered view and contains no full card numbers.	US-028 US-029 US-030
BR-11	Ops and finance report dispute outcomes and win rate using one agreed definition.	P0	Each closed dispute counts in exactly one outcome category under the agreed definitions. The ops dashboard shows volume by status, ageing bands and disputes due in 5 days.	US-031 US-032
BR-18	Dispute ops work disputes from a prioritized queue, including disputes with unmapped reason codes.	P0	Queue lists disputes needing ops action by due date with the reason. Assignments are visible to other analysts. Analysts can categorize unmapped codes and release disputes from manual review.	US-035 US-022
BR-19	Servicing agents can retrieve a merchant's dispute status through an API for their agent console.	P1	Authorized agents retrieve status, due date and last update within 2 seconds. Unauthorized calls are denied and logged.	US-024
BR-20	Product team can measure pilot adoption without collecting personal or card data.	P0	Sign-in, dispute views, uploads and submissions are tracked under the approved plan. No personal or card data is included in events.	US-034 US-005
BR-21	Dispute reasons are shown in plain language with suggested evidence types.	P1	Every mapped reason code shows a plain-language description and suggested evidence types. Codes without a description show the raw code with a 'description pending' label.	US-007
BR-23	Dispute ops can see a linked fraud case reference on a dispute. (pending CR-01)	P1, TBD	Linked fraud case ID and status shown read-only. The dispute still loads if the fraud service is unavailable.	US-036

8. Non-functional and compliance requirements

Area	Requirement	How it's verified	Links
Card data protection (PCI DSS)	Full card numbers are never stored or displayed in evidence, exports or analytics. Card numbers in uploaded files are masked to the last four digits before storage; files that can't be checked are quarantined.	Redaction test set validated by InfoSec before UAT sign-off; weekly scans after launch (KPI-16)	BR-04, CTL-01, CR-03
Encryption	Evidence encrypted at rest with the approved key management service; TLS 1.2 or higher in transit.	Configuration review and TLS scan	BR-14, CTL-02
Access control	Least-privilege roles through SSO; denied attempts logged; 15-minute idle timeout.	Access tests; IAM configuration export	BR-02, CTL-05
Audit trail	Every upload, deletion and submission recorded with user, time, dispute and action. Audit records can't be edited.	Audit log tests	BR-13, CTL-03
Data retention	Evidence retained and deleted according to the approved retention schedule.	Deletion job tests once rules are confirmed	BR-22, CTL-09, A-07
Privacy	No personal or card data in analytics events; pseudonymous user IDs; reminder opt-outs recorded.	Tracking plan privacy review	BR-20, CTL-04
Accessibility	Merchant screens meet WCAG 2.1 AA, including keyboard-only and screen reader use.	Automated and manual audit; no critical or serious issues open	BR-15, CTL-07
Performance	95th percentile API response under 2 seconds at 3x forecast peak volume.	60-minute load test before go-live	BR-16, KPI-14
Data freshness	Status updates applied within 5 minutes at the 95th percentile; alert after 2 hours with no updates.	Status event log monitoring	BR-06, BR-08, KPI-12, KPI-13
Security testing	Independent penetration test; critical and high findings fixed and retested before go-live.	Pen test report and retest	BR-17, CTL-08, D-03
Data quality	Settlement reports reconcile to the finance ledger within 0.5% before release.	Daily quality rules and monthly reconciliation	BR-12, KPI-15
Availability (proposed)	99.9% monthly availability for the merchant portal, excluding planned maintenance windows.	Uptime monitoring	To be confirmed (Q-08)
Supported browsers (proposed)	Latest two versions of Chrome, Edge, Safari and Firefox; responsive down to tablet width.	Cross-browser test pass in SIT	To be confirmed (Q-08)

9. Data, integrations and status model

9.1 Integrations

System	Direction	Purpose	Dependency and status
Payment processor dispute API and webhooks	Inbound and outbound	Ingest disputes, receive status updates, submit evidence and acceptances	D-01 production access at risk (committed one week late); I-01 sandbox status values
Identity platform (SSO)	Inbound	Sign-in and role-based access	D-02 role configuration on track
Card-number redaction service	Internal	Detect and mask card numbers in uploads	CR-03 approved with InfoSec validation condition
Document storage vendor	Outbound	Store redacted evidence files	R-08 vendor security assessment
Settlement pipeline and warehouse	Inbound	Payouts, debits and reversals for reports	D-04 on track for 9 October
Finance ledger extract	Inbound	Monthly reconciliation	KPI-15
Email service	Outbound	Reminders and outcome notifications	US-025, US-026
Amplitude	Outbound	Product analytics	I-06 tracking plan awaiting approval
Power BI	Inbound	Ops and finance dashboards	US-031, US-032
Servicing agent console	Outbound (API)	Dispute status lookup for agents	D-06 on track
Fraud case service	Inbound	Fraud case reference on disputes	D-07 late; only if CR-01 Option C is approved

9.2 Dispute status model

Processor status values are normalized into nine internal statuses. Processor values below are illustrative and must be confirmed against the processor API documentation (A-02).

Internal status	Meaning	Example processor values	Open or closed	Merchant label
New	Dispute received from the processor; no merchant or ops action yet.	NEW, OPENED	Open	New
Awaiting evidence	Merchant can respond and the response deadline is running.	EVIDENCE_REQUIRED, ACTION_NEEDED	Open	Action needed
Evidence submitted	Merchant response has been sent to the processor.	RESPONSE_SUBMITTED	Open	Response sent
Under review	Processor or card network is reviewing the dispute.	UNDER_REVIEW, IN_REVIEW	Open	Under review
Accepted	Merchant accepted the dispute without contesting.	ACCEPTED, MERCHANT_ACCEPTED	Closed	Accepted
Expired	Response deadline passed with no evidence submitted and no acceptance.	EXPIRED, NO_RESPONSE	Closed	Deadline passed
Won	Resolved fully in the merchant's favor.	WON, RESOLVED_MERCHANT	Closed	Won

Internal status	Meaning	Example processor values	Open or closed	Merchant label
Partially won	Resolved with part of the disputed amount returned to the merchant.	PARTIAL_WIN, SPLIT_DECISION	Closed	Partially won
Lost	Resolved in the cardholder's favor after the merchant responded.	LOST, RESOLVED_CARDHOLDER	Closed	Lost

Known defect: during SIT the processor value IN_REVIEW was mapped to Closed instead of Under review (DEF-03). The mapping is covered by test cases TC-029 and TC-030 and a monitoring query that flags any processor status mapped to more than one internal status.

9.3 Dispute outcome definitions (proposed under CR-05)

Finance currently counts partially won disputes as lost; ops counts them as won. The proposal reports each outcome explicitly. It is pending a Business Sponsor decision due 18 September 2026.

Outcome	Counts as contested	Counts as a win	Recovered amount in KPI-01	Proposed rule
Won	Yes	Yes	Full dispute_amount	Won; counts as a win.
Partially won	Yes	No (reported separately)	Amount returned	Own category; recovered amount included in KPI-01.
Lost	Yes	No	0	Lost.
Accepted	No	No	0	Excluded from win rate; tracked as acceptance volume.
Expired	No	No	0	Excluded from win rate; counted in KPI-04 missed-deadline loss rate.

Win rate (KPI-02) = Won ÷ (Won + Partially won + Lost). Partial win rate is reported alongside. On the same 100 illustrative disputes, Finance's current method gives 40%, Ops' gives 62.5%, and the proposal gives 50% with a 12.5% partial win rate.

9.4 Key data entities

Merchant, dispute, reason code, status event, evidence file, portal user, analytics event, ops work item, settlement and ledger entry. Field definitions, owners, quality rules and sensitivity classifications are maintained in the Data Dictionary tab of the KPI Definitions workbook.

10. Experience requirements

10.1 Design principles

- **Deadline first.** Every dispute view leads with how much time is left and what to do next.
- **Plain language.** Reason codes, statuses and errors are written for merchants, not for card network specialists.
- **No dead ends.** Every error explains what happened and how to fix it before the deadline.
- **Accessible by default.** Accessibility checks are part of the Definition of Done for every screen.
- **Trustworthy data.** Show when data was last synced and label anything provisional.

10.2 Key screens

Screen	Purpose	Must include	Design status
Dispute inbox	See and prioritize open disputes	Due date and days left, status, amount, reason; filters; last synced time	Built in Sprints 2–4
Dispute detail	Understand one dispute and act	Timeline, plain-language reason, suggested evidence, submit and accept actions	Built in Sprint 3
Evidence upload and submit	Respond with evidence	File rules, redaction and quarantine messages, draft save (P1), confirmation	Awaiting merchant ops sign-off (I-03, due 15 September)
Settlements	Explain payouts	Payout breakdown, linked debits and reversals, CSV export	Sprint 7
Ops work queue	Work disputes in priority order	Reason for action, assignment, manual review queue	Built in Sprint 2
User management	Control access	Invite, assign role, deactivate	Sprint 6
Onboarding guide	Get new merchants started	Steps for inbox, evidence and reminders; reopen from help	Sprint 8

11. Analytics and instrumentation

Events follow the approved tracking plan (pending I-06). User IDs are pseudonymous, and no names, emails or card data are sent.

Event	Fires when	Key properties	Used by
sign_in	A user signs in	user role, merchant segment	KPI-09
onboarding_completed	A first-time user finishes the guide	steps completed	KPI-11
dispute_viewed	A user opens a dispute	dispute status, days to deadline	KPI-08, KPI-09
evidence_upload_started	A user starts attaching evidence	file count, file types	KPI-10
evidence_submitted	A response is submitted	files submitted, days before deadline	KPI-06, KPI-10
export_csv	A user exports a list	export type, row count band	KPI-09

12. Success metrics

Full definitions, formulas, data sources and measurement readiness are in the KPI Definitions workbook. Targets below are steady-state targets (end-2028, or end-2029 for portal evidence share); the quarterly path is in the Post-Launch Plan. KPI-19 to KPI-21 are proposed metrics for beyond-MVP initiatives and are not yet approved.

12.1 North Star and outcome metrics

Metric	Baseline	Target	Owner	Definition status
KPI-01 Dispute value recovery rate	38%	45%	Finance Lead	Pending decision
KPI-02 Dispute win rate	41%	48%	Finance Lead	Pending decision
KPI-03 On-time response rate	78%	95%	Dispute Ops Lead	Approved
KPI-04 Missed-deadline loss rate	9%	3%	Dispute Ops Lead	Approved
KPI-05 Average ops handling time per dispute	42 min	25 min	Dispute Ops Lead	Approved
KPI-06 Portal evidence submission share	0%	70%	Product Owner	Approved
KPI-07 Settlement support contacts per 100 merchants	14	8	Finance Lead	Proposed
KPI-18 Merchant satisfaction with dispute handling	–	4.2 / 5	Product Owner	Proposed
KPI-19 Disputes resolved before chargeback	–	70%	Dispute Ops Lead	Proposed

12.2 Leading indicators (pilot and rollout)

Metric	Baseline	Target	Owner	Definition status
KPI-08 Pilot merchant activation rate	–	60%	Product Owner	Approved
KPI-09 Weekly active user rate	–	60%	Product Owner	Approved
KPI-10 Evidence submission completion rate	–	85%	Product Owner	Proposed
KPI-11 Onboarding guide completion rate	–	70%	Product Owner	Proposed
KPI-20 AI evidence packet acceptance rate	–	75%	Product Owner	Proposed

12.3 Guardrails

Metric	Baseline	Target	Owner	Definition status
KPI-12 Status sync latency (95th percentile)	–	5 min	Tech Lead	Approved
KPI-13 Feed freshness breaches	–	0	Tech Lead	Approved
KPI-14 API response time (95th percentile)	–	2 s	Tech Lead	Approved
KPI-15 Settlement reconciliation variance	–	0.5%	Finance Lead	Approved
KPI-16 Card data exposure incidents	–	0	Compliance Lead	Approved

Metric	Baseline	Target	Owner	Definition status
KPI-17 Open critical or serious accessibility issues	–	0	UX Designer	Approved
KPI-21 Merchants near a monitoring threshold	–	1%	Merchant Relationship Lead	Proposed

12.4 Business value

Scenario	NPV (3 years)	3-year ROI	Payback after go-live
Conservative	(\$839k)	(59%)	Beyond 3 years
Base	\$149k	26%	2.3 years
Optimistic	\$1.34M	138%	1.2 years

About 85% of base-case benefits come from released ops capacity, counted only at the cashable share. Merchant value of about \$771k a year at Year 3 (money recovered or kept by merchants) is excluded from NPV.

13. Release plan and milestones

Phase	Dates	Scope or audience	Exit gate
Build (Sprints 1–8)	20 Jul – 6 Nov 2026	MVP features; SIT each sprint	Sprint reviews; Definition of Done
Hardening and UAT (Sprints 9–10)	9 Nov – 4 Dec 2026	Security remediation, UAT, load and accessibility testing	UAT sign-off; critical and high pen test findings fixed; redaction validated
Go-live	11 Dec 2026	Production launch with internal users	Go / no-go on 4 Dec (RV-01)
Hypercare	11 Dec 2026 – 22 Jan 2027	Stabilization through holiday change freeze	12 exit criteria, including 10 business days with no Sev 1 or Sev 2
Pilot	11 Jan – 5 Mar 2027	10 enterprise e-commerce merchants	Activation ≥ 60% (KPI-08), on-time response ≥ 90%, zero card data incidents
Wave 1	15 Mar – 28 May 2027	Enterprise e-commerce and mid-market online retail	Portal share ≥ 35%, missed-deadline loss ≤ 5%
Wave 2	7 Jun – 24 Sep 2027	Subscription and digital services; travel and hospitality	Portal share ≥ 50%, handling time ≤ 30 min
General availability	4 Oct – 17 Dec 2027	All remaining merchants, self-serve	Email intake retired for portal-enabled merchants

Status as of 10 September 2026: Sprint 4 of 10 in progress; 80 of 252 MVP points done (32%); two items blocked (US-019 by I-01, US-034 by I-06).

14. Dependencies, risks and assumptions

14.1 Dependencies

ID	Dependency	Provider	Needed by	Status
D-01	Processor dispute API production access	Payment processor	16 Oct 2026	At risk (committed 23 Oct)
D-02	Merchant roles in identity platform	IAM team	2 Oct 2026	On track
D-03	Penetration test before UAT	InfoSec	30 Oct 2026	At risk (committed 13 Nov); CR-06 raised
D-04	Settlement data pipeline	Data Engineering	9 Oct 2026	On track
D-05	Merchant portal terms of use	Legal & Compliance	23 Oct 2026	Not started
D-06	Dispute status API for servicing console	Project team (outbound)	27 Nov 2026	On track
D-07	Fraud case-ID service	Fraud Platform team	6 Nov 2026	Late (committed 11 Dec); linking proposed for Phase 2

14.2 Top risks

ID	Risk	Score	Mitigation
R-04	Merchants keep using email instead of the portal	16 High	Pilot with 10 high-volume merchants, in-portal onboarding, adoption tracking, email intake retired wave by wave
R-02	Card numbers in evidence expand PCI DSS scope	15 High	Automated redaction on upload (CR-03), quarantine, InfoSec validation
R-03	Status sync lag causes missed deadlines	15 High	Feed freshness alerts, 'last synced' timestamp, reminders at 5 and 2 days
R-01	Card network rule changes before go-live	12 Medium	Configurable reason codes and response windows (CR-02)
R-05	Legacy settlement data quality undermines reports	12 Medium	Data quality rules, exception report, reconciliation before sign-off
R-07	Scope creep from fraud case management requests	12 Medium	Change control; Option C proposed; Phase 2 roadmap commitment
R-06	Limited SME availability during Q4 peak	9 Medium	Book UAT time now; backup SMEs; recorded walkthroughs
R-09	Performance at peak chargeback volume	8 Medium	Load test at 3x peak; autoscaling; performance targets in acceptance criteria

14.3 Key assumptions

ID	Assumption	Status
A-01	Merchants will submit evidence through the portal instead of email	Validating in pilot
A-02	Processor webhooks provide near real-time status updates	Validating (sandbox issues, I-01)
A-03	Identity platform supports Admin, Finance and Operations roles	Confirmed

ID	Assumption	Status
A-04	MVP supports USD and English only	Unvalidated; confirm at scope baseline
A-05	Dispute ops headcount stays flat during MVP	Unvalidated
A-06	12 months of dispute history available for baselines	Validating
A-07	Evidence can follow the existing records retention policy	Validating with Legal

15. Open questions and decisions needed

ID	Question	Owner	Needed by	Blocking?
Q-01	How are dispute outcomes and win rate defined? (CR-05)	Business Sponsor with Finance and Dispute Ops Leads	18 Sep 2026	Yes, for reporting stories US-031 and US-032
Q-02	Are Merchant evidence upload designs approved? (I-03)	Dispute Ops Lead via design authority	15 Sep 2026	Yes, for Sprint 5
Q-03	Is a read-only fraud case reference in MVP scope? (CR-01 Option C)	Steering Committee	24 Sep 2026	No; affects US-036 only
Q-04	Can UAT start in parallel with the delayed penetration test? (CR-06)	Steering Committee with Compliance	25 Sep 2026	Yes, for the UAT plan
Q-05	Is the analytics tracking plan approved? (I-06)	Data Governance Lead	1 Oct 2026	Yes, for pilot activation metrics
Q-06	Should SMS reminders be added, and at what cost? (CR-09)	Product Owner after assessment	2 Oct 2026	No
Q-07	What are the evidence retention and deletion rules? (A-07)	Legal Counsel	9 Oct 2026	Yes, for US-014 and BR-22 tests
Q-08	Confirm availability target and supported browsers	Tech Lead	16 Oct 2026	No
Q-09	How much released ops capacity is cashable? (LR-17)	Finance Lead with Dispute Ops Lead	30 Oct 2026	No; affects the business case

16. Launch readiness and post-launch

16.1 Go-live readiness

Go-live requires UAT sign-off, critical and high penetration test findings fixed, InfoSec validation of redaction accuracy, a passed load test, trained dispute ops and servicing teams, a tested rollback plan, a hypercare rota, and all must-have KPIs ready to measure. Readiness is tracked item by item on the Launch Readiness tab of the Business Case & GTM workbook.

16.2 Hypercare

Hypercare runs from 11 December 2026 to 22 January 2027 and ends on evidence, not on a date. Exit requires 10 consecutive business days with no open Sev 1 or Sev 2 incidents, status sync p95 at or under 5 minutes, zero card data incidents, runbooks accepted by the run team and support tiers operating without delivery team help.

16.3 Measuring and iterating

KPIs are reviewed daily during hypercare, weekly by the Product Owner, monthly with the Business Sponsor and quarterly with the steering committee. Twelve KPI triggers turn signals into named actions; for example, pilot activation below 45% at week 4 starts a call to every inactive merchant. Improvements from pilot feedback and KPI triggers are prioritized on the iteration roadmap, starting with pilot fixes and a merchant satisfaction survey.

16.4 Beyond MVP: from processing to prevention

Discovery showed that online dispute portals are already standard, including American Express's own online Disputes tool, Stripe and Razorpay (DSC-06). The MVP therefore competes on safety, clarity and operations, and the roadmap adds differentiation through prevention and explainable AI. These initiatives are proposals, not MVP commitments; wireframes S09 to S13 illustrate them.

Initiative	Horizon	What it does	Measure	Gate before commitment
RM-28 Dispute ratio health alerts	Next (Q2 2027)	Shows how close merchants are to card network monitoring thresholds, including Amex's own programs, with alerts at 60% and 80%	KPI-21	Ratio data source and thresholds confirmed with the acquirer
RM-25 Pre-dispute alerts and early refunds	Next (Q3 2027)	Resolves eligible disputes before chargeback through programs such as Amex Accelerated Dispute Resolution	KPI-19	Alert programs and costs confirmed; Wave 1 exit
RM-26 AI evidence copilot (pilot)	Next (Q3–Q4 2027)	Drafts evidence packets from connected systems with sources shown, win likelihood, and human review above a set amount	KPI-20	AI model risk review (MS-11, 17 Jun 2027); Phase 2 funding (MS-09)
RM-27 Friendly fraud evidence automation	Later (Q1 2028)	Matches earlier undisputed purchases to meet Visa Compelling Evidence 3.0 and Mastercard First-Party Trust rules	KPI-02	Network eligibility rules confirmed
RM-29 Root-cause insights	Later (H1 2028)	Shows which products, billing names and channels create disputes, with recommended fixes	KPI-04	Minimum data volume; 2028 planning
RM-30 AI agent purchase readiness	Later (Q2–Q3 2028)	Stores AI shopping agent authorization records and tracks agent disputes as their own channel	KPI-21	Agent token standards mature; 2028 planning

17. Appendices

Appendix A: Glossary

Term	Meaning
Dispute (chargeback)	A cardholder's challenge to a card transaction, raised through their card issuer and card network
Reason code	The card network code describing why a transaction was disputed; it sets evidence needs and the response window

Term	Meaning
Response window	Days a merchant has to respond before the dispute is lost by default
Evidence package	Files and a response note submitted to contest a dispute
Contested dispute	A dispute with a final outcome of Won, Partially won or Lost
Chargeback debit and reversal	Money taken from a merchant's payout when a dispute is raised, and returned if the merchant wins
Portal evidence share	Share of evidence packages submitted through the portal rather than by email
p95	95th percentile: the value that 95% of measurements are at or below
PCI DSS	Payment Card Industry Data Security Standard for protecting cardholder data
WCAG 2.1 AA	Web Content Accessibility Guidelines conformance level used for customer-facing screens
Hypercare	Period of heightened support straight after go-live
SIT and UAT	System integration testing by the delivery team; user acceptance testing by business users

Appendix B: Traceability to project artifacts

Artifact	What it holds	IDs referenced in this PRD
RAID Log	Risks, assumptions, issues and dependencies	R-, A-, I-, D-
Change Log	Change requests, impact assessments and decisions	CR-
Product Backlog	Epics, user stories with acceptance criteria, sprint plan	EP-, US-
Requirements Traceability Matrix	Requirements, test cases, defects and compliance controls	BR-, TC-, DEF-, CTL-
KPI Definitions	Metric catalog, outcome definitions, data dictionary	KPI-
Business Case & GTM Plan	Financial model, segments, rollout plan, launch readiness	LR-, BC-
Engagement Plan	Stakeholders, RACI, governance, communications, deliverables	SH-, RA-, CM-, DL-
Post-Launch Plan	Hypercare, support model, KPI triggers, benefits tracker, roadmap	EX-, TR-, IR-, RV-, LL-
SQL Practice Pack	Queries for every KPI and data quality check on simulated data	KPI-, DEF-, I-
Product Roadmap	Themes, initiatives, milestones and gates, July 2026 to December 2028	RM-, MS-
Product Discovery & Decision Log	Market and internal findings, sources, and decisions with status	DSC-, SRC-
Wireframes	Annotated MVP and concept screens with rules and open questions	S01 to S13

Appendix C: Revision history

Version	Date	Author	Changes
1.0	11 Sep 2026	Bhawna	First complete draft for review, consolidating discovery findings, backlog, RTM, KPI definitions, business case and rollout plan
1.1	11 Sep 2026	Bhawna	Added 'The project in plain words' overview before the executive summary
1.2	11 Sep 2026	Bhawna	Added beyond-MVP section 16.4 and non-goal, proposed KPI-19 to KPI-21, steady-state target timing, and traceability to the roadmap, decision log and wireframes